

Avocettina infans

Avocet snipe eel



Length Up to 30 in (75 cm)
Weight 1 lb (0.5 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location Tropical, subtropical, and temperate waters worldwide

A deep-sea eel with a brown or black body, the avocet snipe eel belongs to a family of about 9 species. Its jaws cannot be fully closed and

have numerous teeth. It probably feeds exclusively on small crustaceans. Young male and female avocet snipe eels look very similar, but as the males approach sexual maturity, they undergo a marked transformation. Their jaws become drastically shortened, and all their teeth are lost. At this stage, males and females look so different that at one time they were classed in separate families. Little known, it is usually only captured by specially designed, deep-sea fishing gear during scientific research expeditions.

*Myrichthys colubrinus*

Banded snake eel



Length Up to 37½ in (95 cm)
Weight 6½ lb (3 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location Indian Ocean, W. Pacific



There are over 300 species of snake eels worldwide and they occur in a wide range of colors and shapes. They are mostly less than 3¼ ft (1 m) long, and burrow in shallow, sandy and muddy bottoms of lagoons, sandy flats, and reefs. This species has a hardened, sharply pointed tail, modified for burrowing tail-first into the sand. Primarily active at night, it feeds on sand-dwelling fishes and crustaceans, and seems to detect its prey by smell.

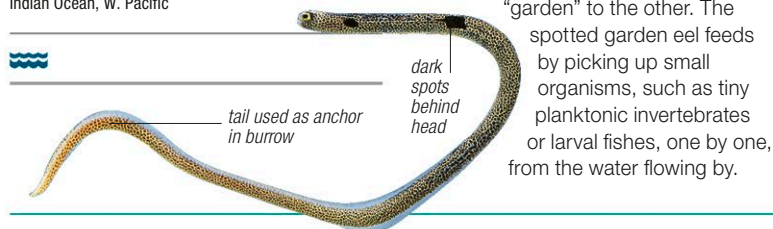
Heteroconger hassi

Spotted garden eel



Length Up to 14 in (36 cm)
Weight 4½ lb (2 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location Red Sea, Indian Ocean, W. Pacific



This eel lives in large colonies, with the lower half of its body buried in the sandy seabed. The upper half of its body projects into the water, creating "gardens" that sway gracefully with the current. When a colony is approached by a diver, the eels nearest the diver slowly sink, each into its individual burrow, to hide from the intruder, in perfect gradation from one end of the "garden" to the other. The spotted garden eel feeds by picking up small organisms, such as tiny planktonic invertebrates or larval fishes, one by one, from the water flowing by.

Saccopharynx ampullaceus

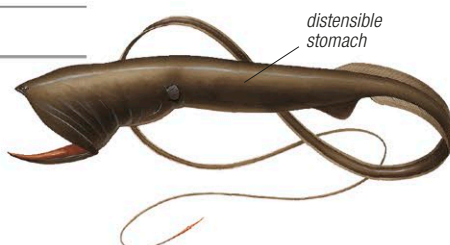
Gulper eel



Length Up to 5¼ ft (1.6 m)
Weight 2¼ lb (1 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location North Atlantic

The gulper eel is a relative of the pelican eel (see right), with a similar small head and large jaws (although smaller than the



pelican eel's). It also has a luminescent organ at the tip of its tail which, if dangled in front of its mouth, may be used to entice prey. It is thought that this fish swims slowly, with its enormous jaws swung open so that its prey literally swims into its mouth. A little-studied fish, the gulper eel belongs to a rare family, known from fewer than 100 specimens.

Conger conger

Conger eel



Length 8¼ ft (2.7 m)
Weight 145 lb (65 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean

This dark gray, thick-bodied fish is one of nearly 200 species in the conger family. As with most eels, it has no scales. With its large size and well-equipped jaws providing protection from most predators, it hunts at night for fishes, crustaceans, and cephalopods. The conger eel is considered an excellent food fish and is frequently caught by anglers. It can be found on rocky and sandy bottoms, at depths of up to 1,640 ft (500 m). While juveniles live inshore, adults move offshore as they grow and mature. The female conger eel lays between 3 and 8 million eggs, which hatch to produce transparent, eel-like larvae. These drift

IN HIDING



Like most of its relatives, the conger eel hides during the day in crevices, emerging at night to chase and ambush prey. Small conger eels are sometimes found in tide pools on rocky shores, as well as in rocky offshore habitats, while large ones often inhabit wrecks of sunken ships.

inshore for 1–2 years before growing into juvenile eels; they reach sexual maturity at 5–15 years.

SNAKELIKE FISH

The conger eel, with its snakelike form and long snout, can slip into small crevices in search of its prey.

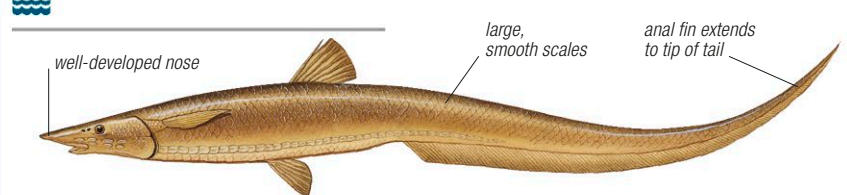
*Aldrovandia affinis*

Halosaur



Length Up to 22 in (55 cm)
Weight 13 lb (6 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

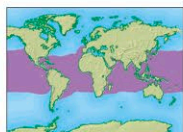
Location Tropical, subtropical, and temperate waters worldwide



This relatively rare fish is found hovering over the bottom in water between 2,300 and 6,600 ft (700–2,000 m) deep. This species is usually only captured by specially designed, deep-sea fishing gear during scientific research expeditions. Little is known about the halosaur but its well-developed nasal organs, particularly among the males, seems to indicate that sense of smell is a means of communication between the sexes.

Eurypharynx pelecyanoides

Pelican eel



Length 23½–39 in (60–100 cm)
Weight 2¼ lb (1 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location Tropical and subtropical waters worldwide

This deep-sea fish is one of the most unusual of eels, with a thin, tapering body, but

enormous jaws equipped with tiny teeth. Its huge gape and expandable stomach enable it to swallow and digest fishes almost as large as itself. Due to its odd shape and fragile build, the pelican eel is almost certainly a poor swimmer and may not pursue other fishes. Instead, it probably relies heavily on the luminescent organ at the tip of the tail to attract prey.

